

ACA, Cancillería, f. 20r — Joan I to Juan Fernández de Heredia, Master of the Hospital of Rhodes

Document Summary

Field	Value
Archive	Arxiu de la Corona d'Aragó, Cancillería
Folio	f. 20r
Date of issue	19 March 1387
Place of issue	Barcelona (<i>Barchinona</i>)
Issuer	Joan I of Aragon (acceded 5 January 1387)
Addressee	Juan Fernández de Heredia (Joan Ferrández d'Heredia), Master of the Order of the Hospital of St. John of Jerusalem (of Rhodes), then resident at Avignon
Language	Aragonese (with Catalan-leaning forms in <i>masclo</i> , <i>femella</i>)
Document type	<i>Lletra missiva</i> — personal royal letter
Seal	Privy seal (<i>siello priuado</i> / <i>segell secret</i>)
Iussio	ff[ranciscus] ça Costa (Francesc ça Costa, vice-chancellor)
Subject	Acknowledgment of receipt of four Rhodian saker falcons intercepted at Barcelona en route from Heredia; request for further falcons; request for four (or more) Turkish greyhounds; outgoing gift of two podencos and a <i>sorgui/sorguina</i> pair

Reconciled Transcription

1	Maestro, caro amigo, aqui en Barchin[on]a han aduyto quatro falcones sacres de Rodas los quals
2	leuan a vos, e nos, sabiendo que eran v[uest]ros, plaziendo nos de vos assi como de amigo, hauemos

3 los v[uest]ros por tanto bueno e agradeçemos vos lo muyto[?], e Rogamos vos
que si algun vos
4 ne embiaredes, que nos en fagades part. Otrossi vos Rogamos quens prestets
.iiij. gual-
5 gos o mas si podedes, d[e] los de Turquia. Nos vos embiamos con el portador de
la p[re]sent
6 dos podencos e un sorgui[?] e una sorguina[?], masclo o femella. Si mas ne
queredes,
7 e enbiat[?] nos lo a dezir, que nos vos ne enviaremos de buen grado. Dada en
Barchin[on]a,
8 sub n[uest]ro siello privado, a .xix. dias de março del anyo de la nat[ivit]at
de n[uest]ro s[enyo]r
.M.CCC.LXXX.VII. – ff[ranciscus] ça Costa.

English Translation

Master, our dear friend: here in Barcelona they have brought four saker falcons from Rhodes,¹ which they were carrying to you;² and we, knowing that they were yours, [the falcons] being pleasing to us coming from you as from a friend,³ have received what is yours as so good a thing, and we thank you for it greatly.⁴ And we pray you that if you send us any [more] of them,⁵ you will give us a share. Likewise we pray you to lend us four greyhounds,⁶ or more if you can, from those of Turkey.⁷ We are sending you with the bearer of the present [letter] two *podencos*⁸ and a male *sorgui*[?], and a female *sorguina*[?],⁹ male or female.¹⁰ If you would like more of them, send us word telling us,¹¹ [and] we will send them to you willingly. Given at Barcelona, under our privy seal,¹² on the 19th day of March in the year of the Nativity of our Lord 1387.¹³ — Franciscus ça Costa.¹⁴

Footnotes

Prosopographical Note on the Addressee

The identification of the addressee as **Juan Fernández de Heredia** (Aragonese *Joan Ferrández d'Heredia*; c. 1310–1396), Master of the Order of the Hospital of St. John of Jerusalem from 24 September 1377, fits the document at every relevant axis:

- **Salutation:** *Maestro, caro amigo* is the appropriate Aragonese register for the king to address a *maestre* of a military order who is also a long-standing intimate of the royal house. Heredia had been a key figure in the court of Pere III since the 1340s and the principal patron of Aragonese literary production at Avignon.

- **Language:** The use of Aragonese (rather than Catalan or Latin) is consistent with Heredia, who was himself the patron of the so-called *escuela de traductores* at Avignon and the sponsor of the major Aragonese translations of Plutarch, Thucydides, and the *Grant Crònica de Espanya*. Aragonese was the language of his cultural project; Joan addresses him in it.
- **Location:** In 1387 Heredia was resident at Avignon, serving as a senior figure in the Avignonese curia under Clement VII; he had been involved in the affairs of the Avignon obedience since the outbreak of the Schism in 1378. A shipment of falcons traveling from the eastern Mediterranean toward Avignon would plausibly stop at Barcelona.
- **Eastern Mediterranean networks:** Heredia's command of the Hospitaller infrastructure — Rhodes itself, the Order's Aegean possessions, and the diplomatic reach into Anatolia and the Levant — uniquely positioned him to procure *both* the Rhodian sakers acknowledged in the letter *and* the Turkish greyhounds Joan requests.

The letter is therefore a small but illuminating document for the cultural and political continuity between the courts of Pere III and Joan I in the first months of the latter's reign: Heredia, the great Aragonese cultural-diplomatic figure of the elder generation, is still the king's go-to broker for prestige goods from the eastern Mediterranean, and Joan addresses him with affective intimacy and an easy claim on his Mediterranean reach.

Unresolved Ambiguities

1. **L3, *muyto* vs *mucho*** — both readings are paleographically defensible; I have preferred *muyto* on dialectal grounds (consistency with the otherwise pure Aragonese register), but this is not decisive. Worth comparing against other letters in the same scribal hand.
2. **L6, *sorgui* / *sorguina*** — the lexical identification of these animals remains open. The initial *s-* is paleographically secure (per Jonathan's reading); the term does not map cleanly onto standard Aragonese or Catalan hunting-stock vocabulary. CICA lookup on *sorgu-*, *çorgu-*, and adjacent roots recommended. Whatever the animal, the masculine/feminine pairing and the contextual association with *podencos* indicate a working/hunting animal.
3. **L6, *masclo* o *femella*** — the Catalan-leaning forms (rather than Aragonese *macho*/*mascho* and *fembra*) are unusual in an otherwise consistent Aragonese register. Whether this reflects the scribe's regional formation, a formulaic crossover from Catalan-language chancery output, or something else worth tracking is open.
4. **L7, *enbiat* (vs *certifficat*)** — preferred per Jonathan's reading but the initial graphic shape is admittedly compatible with a double-*ff*-headed *certifficat*. The resolution depends on a closer inspection of the line opening than the present image affords.
5. **Document identity:** The register and folio context within ACA, Cancillería need to be confirmed against the full archival reference, since the present image shows only the lower part of a folio (f. 20r), and the *intitulatio* / *inscriptio* are not present in the image.

Confirmation that this is indeed a privy-seal register or the corresponding letterbook would tie down the diplomatic context.

6. **Sequel evidence:** If Heredia in fact dispatched Turkish greyhounds to Barcelona later in 1387 or 1388, the corresponding incoming acknowledgment should appear in the registers of those years. Worth tracking as a possible follow-up.
1. *Sacres de Rodas* — saker falcons (*Falco cherrug*) of Rhodian provenance. Sakers were highly prized for Iberian and Mediterranean falconry; their range extends from the Balkans across Anatolia and central Asia, so Rhodes — as the Order of the Hospital's eastern Mediterranean headquarters since 1309 — was a logical intermediate market for birds trapped or trained further east. The specification "de Rodas" frames these as prestige birds with a clear chain of provenance, and locates Heredia's procurement network at the eastern end of the Order's reach. ↵
2. *Los quals leuan a vos* — i.e., the falcons were being delivered from Heredia's agents to Heredia himself (presumably at Avignon), but passed through Barcelona, where they came to Joan's attention. The letter implicitly acknowledges that Joan has appropriated falcons in transit and not destined for him in the first place; the rest of the document is in essence a polite *post hoc* solicitation of Heredia's consent and a return gift to balance the books. ↵
3. *Plaziendo nos de vos assi como de amigo* — the participial absolute construction here ("being pleasing to us from you as from a friend") frames the appropriation as an act between intimates. *Assi como de amigo* — "as from a friend" — is the affective register that licenses the appropriation and that the rest of the letter sustains throughout. ↵
4. *Havemos los vuestros por tanto bueno* — Aragonese *tener por X*, "to consider as X." The phrase reads "we hold what is yours as so good a thing," which functions both as a thank-you and as a formal acceptance of the falcons as gift rather than seizure. The orthography *muyto/mucho* on the adverb is paleographically ambiguous; I have preferred the Aragonese *muyto*, consistent with the dialectal register elsewhere in the letter, but the case is not closed. ↵
5. *Si algun vos ne embiaredes, que nos en fagades part* — "if you send us any, that you give us a share." The construction with pronominal *ne* (= "thereof") is standard Aragonese; the request is for a continuing share in future shipments rather than a one-time gift. ↵
6. *Gualgos* (= *galgos*) — Iberian sighthounds, a category distinct from the *podencos* (scenthounds) Joan offers in return; see notes 8 and 9. The *gualgo/galgo* designation in Aragonese chancery usage typically denotes a hare-coursing or open-country sighthound rather than a boar-or-stag specialist. ↵
7. *D[e] los de Turquia* — the specification is significant. By the 1380s "Turquia" in Aragonese usage covered the Anatolian Beyliks and (after Kosovo, 1389) increasingly the Ottoman polity; Heredia, with the Order's eastern Mediterranean network including Rhodes and the *Compagnia*-period possessions in Greece, was perhaps uniquely positioned within Joan's correspondence circle to procure Anatolian hunting stock. The request thus telegraphs Joan's view of Heredia's reach: not simply a curial diplomat at Avignon, but a *de facto*

broker for Eastern Mediterranean luxury goods. Whether the request was fulfilled would be worth checking against later 1387–88 registers. ↵

8. *Podencos* — Iberian scenthounds; in 14th-century Aragonese usage typically a small-to-medium quarry hound used in pairs or packs. Their offer here against incoming sakers and outgoing Turkish *galgos* maps a deliberate East/West exchange: the gift Heredia receives is unmistakably Iberian; the gift Joan asks for is unmistakably Anatolian. ↵
9. *Un sorgui e una sorguina* — the masculine/feminine pair is paleographically secure, but the lexical identification of the animal is not. The term does not correspond to a standard Aragonese or Catalan hunting-stock vocabulary item known to me. The pairing with *podencos* strongly suggests a hunting or working animal rather than livestock; possibilities worth checking against CICA include (a) a regional or scribal variant of a recognized hound term, (b) a ferret or other small mustelid used in rabbiting, or (c) a small game-bird kept as a breeding pair. **Flagged in unresolved ambiguities.** ↵
10. *Masclo o femella* — "male or female." The Catalan-leaning forms *masclo* (rather than Aragonese *macho/mascho*) and *femella* (rather than *fembra*) are unusual in an otherwise consistently Aragonese letter; they may reflect the chancery scribe's regional formation, or a scribal habit imported from formulaic phrasing used elsewhere in the chancery. The phrase appears slightly redundant given the immediately preceding *un sorgui e una sorguina* (which already encodes a male/female pair); the most plausible reading is that *masclo o femella* is a generalizing tag covering the whole list of outgoing animals — i.e., "[among them] male or female" — rather than a third specification of the *sorgui* pair alone. ↵
11. *E enbiat nos lo a dezir* — the Aragonese imperative plural *enbiat* (= *enbiad*) governs the construction "send word to us to tell us [so]." The grammar is awkward — *enbiat nos lo* with the *lo* as proleptic object of the infinitive *a dezir* — but parseable. An alternative reading *certifficat nos lo a dezir* ("notify us in writing") would be grammatically cleaner but is not supported by the manuscript on closer inspection. ↵
12. *Sub n[uest]ro siello priuado* — the privy seal (Cat. *segell secret*; sometimes *petit anell*) authenticated personal royal letters, as opposed to the great seal used on chancery-formal acts (concessions, mandates, etc.). The use of the privy seal here is consistent with the document's status as a friendly *lletra missiva* between social near-equals. ↵
13. *Anyo de la nat[ivit]at de n[uest]ro s[enyo]r .M.CCC.LXXX.VII.* — the Crown of Aragon used Nativity-style dating (year change at 25 December), so the document's date is straightforwardly **19 March 1387** in modern reckoning. Joan acceded on 5 January 1387 following the death of his father Pere III/IV the Ceremonious; the letter is thus written approximately ten weeks into the new reign, a moment when Joan was still in Barcelona consolidating after his accession and not yet on the prolonged itineraries that would mark his later 1387 movements. ↵
14. *Ffranciscus ça Costa* — Francesc ça Costa, vice-chancellor of Joan I, serves here as the *iussio* — i.e., the chancery officer attesting that the letter was issued by royal mandate. His name appears as *iussio* on a substantial range of Joan I's chancery output across spring

1387, and the attribution is consistent with his known activity. The relatively unceremonious format of this letter (privy seal, single *iussio* line, no further attestation) reflects its character as a personal communication rather than a chancery-formal act. ↵